

Inside von der Leyen's social media strategy

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin, wishing you as painless a rentrée as possible.

In today's Playbook:

- Capitals try (again) to convince Belgium to release Russia's frozen assets.
- Icelanders vote on whether to take a first step toward EU membership.
- Faces in the crowd: Maria Malmer Stenergard, Henna Virkkunen, Maxime Prévot, Andris Kulbergs, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, Manuela Schwesig, Emmanuel Macron, Bart De Wever, Paweł Zalewski, Amelia Andersdotter and more.

On the Brussels Playbook Week Ender Podcast: Anne talks to János Bóka, the new parliamentary leader of Hungary's Fidesz party, about whether Viktor Orbán could make a return.

DRIVING THE DAY

YOU'VE BEEN LOGGED OUT: Ursula von der Leyen's landmark policy banning social media for minors is set to be watered down because of possible legal challenges and conflicting views from national capitals. The European Commission president will now use her Sept. 16 State of the EU speech to announce restrictions for children under 13 that include a host of carveouts, two officials working on the proposal told me and Eliza Gkritsi.

Inside the plan: The revised proposal would allow children to get online with the permission of their parents. The workaround is designed to avoid clashes with EU laws on the fundamental rights of citizens while allowing von der Leyen to push ahead with what has become a personal priority.

Legal issues: "A delay on when minors can access social media, and flexibility for parents that choose otherwise, will be beneficial and compatible with fundamental rights," said one of the officials, granted anonymity to speak frankly. The intention is to produce a standalone proposal for future legislation, which will be a major focus of von der Leyen's Strasbourg speech (which is still being written, with no proposals locked in).

Shot across the bow: A French court earlier this month handed French President Emmanuel Macron a defeat by ruling his proposed ban on social media for children under 15 breached EU laws . Macron has vowed to get a law through by spring 2027 but the ruling has been a reality check for officials drafting Brussels' measures. Opt-outs for parental supervision are now seen as a way to avoid such problems.

Even if EU rules supersede national laws and set a bloc-wide minimum age, countries might have some flexibility to raise the age. But the underlying problem remains: Not every government agrees on what the threshold age should be.

Numbers game: Macron wants 15 ... Germany is more supportive of a 13-year age limit ... Austria has proposed 14 ... Spain is going for 16 ... and Estonia wants a focus on harm limitation rather than blanket measures.

Keep scrolling: Another plank of the EU social media push is a renewed campaign to get companies to redesign addictive features that entice children to scroll for hours at a time, the officials said. So far, the bloc has had little luck getting companies to pay attention.

But that could change: Meta's \$18 billion settlement with nearly all U.S. states earlier this week sparked hopes that platforms may now be ready to examine entrenched excessive use among children.

Expert view: Claire Boine, assistant professor of technology law at the European University Institute, told Playbook that "targeting addictive design will be one of the most powerful steps the EU can take" and that while the bloc will have to avoid legal hurdles, "a well-designed law could do a lot of good."

Note of caution: My U.K. colleague Mizy Clifton writes this morning that academics in Britain fear the country's planned social media bans are a shot in the dark .

BIG AND BREAKING

CALL IT BY ITS NAME: Russia's hybrid war against Europe is looking increasingly like a real war , prompting a call for the EU to reconsider the language it uses to describe it, Nicholas Vinocur and Antoaneta Roussi report.

RUSSIAN EXODUS: Fears the Kremlin is preparing to step up efforts to draft young men to fight in Ukraine may be linked to a spike in the number of Russians leaving the country via the land border with Georgia, Daria Zakharova writes.

GREEN ROUTE TO POWER: French far-left presidential contender Jean-Luc Mélenchon is looking to the country's Greens to deliver him a victory in next year's election.

UNFROZEN ARGUMENTS

THE FROZEN ASSETS CLASH RETURNS: Sweden, the Netherlands, Poland and Spain have written a letter urging the EU to revisit a plan to use €210 billion in frozen Russian funds frozen to support Ukraine, after months of stalemate. Advocates for the proposal tell Playbook a deal is possible.

Belgium shot the plan down at a tense EU summit in December, fearing that the legal basis was not sound and could lead to the country being singled out for lawsuits from Moscow.

Staunch supporters: Latvian Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs told my colleague Max Grier that the discussion should “definitely” be back on the table because it’s a “no-brainer” that’s “in the interests of all Europeans.”

Look at the big picture: Moscow breaches every rule but expects the EU to uphold the rules that applies to Russia, Kulbergs said. “I think that is the wrong approach,” he said, adding that Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever and others shouldn’t let their concerns override the need to gain access to the funds.

Bullish: “Belgium has been informed about the letter beforehand … We respect Belgium’s concerns,” Swedish Foreign Minister Maria Malmer Stenergard told Jacopo Barigazzi. The key, according to the minister, lies in what Belgian Foreign Minister Maxime Prévot highlighted in the recent leaders’ meeting in Kyiv: “Possible risks need to be shared in solidarity between all member states. It is also key that no single member state holds a disproportionate burden.”

Nee, non, nein: But Belgium, which hosts the Euroclear depository that holds the majority of the funds, shows no sign of backing down. Prévot told Camille Gijs he had taken note of the letter but “Belgium’s position is well-known and consistent. It has not changed since last year. In particular, the risks associated with using these assets have not miraculously disappeared.” He will raise the issue at next week’s foreign ministers’ summit in Ireland.

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ICELAND REFERENDUM

POLLS ARE NARROWING: Support for reopening Iceland’s talks to join the EU has narrowed ahead of tomorrow’s referendum, although “yes” remains slightly ahead, Zoya Sheftalovich writes. The latest Maskína poll found 51.3 percent in favor of resuming talks against 48.7 percent for “no” — a gap within the poll’s margin of error.

The logistics: Polling stations are generally open from 9 a.m. to 10 p.m. Around 272,000 Icelandic citizens are registered to vote, including 17,000 living abroad, according to Iceland’s National Registry . More than 40,000 people have already cast their ballots in early voting.

The question: “Should Iceland reopen accession negotiations with the European Union?” The referendum isn’t legally binding, but Iceland’s government has said it will restart discussions with Brussels if “yes” wins. Preparations are already underway to assemble negotiating teams, with talks likely to begin within weeks or possibly two months, said a person familiar with the preparations, granted anonymity to speak freely on a sensitive topic.

A “no” vote would park the issue, though a very narrow outcome could mean the debate comes up again, the person said.

Money, money, money: The campaign has focused more on economic questions — particularly the possibility of adopting the euro — than on security and defense.

When will we know the results? Counting begins when polls close, with results coming in from 10:30 p.m. to midnight. A clear result may emerge overnight or on Sunday.

NOW READ THIS: One Icelandic millionaire has been the force behind the country's whale hunting industry for decades — but all that could change when Icelanders vote Saturday, Carlo Martuscelli reports from Reykjavik.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. It has now landed in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

PRESIDENTIAL KICKOFF: Seven of France's presidential contenders went head-to-head in Paris yesterday, with no clear winner — and no shared vision for Europe , as Victor Goury-Laffont explains.

REMEMBER THE WALL? Germany's far right is dialing up the nostalgia for East German communism to boost its vote.

NO TO NUKES, YES TO DETERRENCE: Poland doesn't want nuclear warheads on its territory but remains committed to NATO nuclear deterrence, according to Deputy Defense Minister Paweł Zalewski.

SPINELESS EUROPE: In this week's Declassified column, Paul Dallison ponders whether jellyfish are taking over the world .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cooler with a few showers. High of 22C.

LAST FESTIVALS OF SUMMER: It feels like the final weekend of freedom before the rentrée — and Brussels is making the most of it, with seemingly every green corner of town filling up with food trucks and stages. There may be some light rain Saturday afternoon and evening, but don't let that ruin the last hurrah.

Here's your Playbook guide to squeezing out the last drops of summer:

Cinquantenaire: Fiesta Latina celebrates its 25th anniversary with Latin music, colorful costumes, tropical cocktails and even lucha libre — plus after-parties stretching into the night. From this afternoon through Sunday.

Abbaye de Forest: The gorgeous green space in front of Forest town hall hosts two stages , a DJ garden and roaming performers Friday and Saturday for the commune's traditional summer send-off. Free entry.

Parc Élisabeth: Prefer brocante, folk and country music — and getting your hair done? Plazey Festival is your weekend , running Friday through Sunday with plenty for the kids too.

Tour & Taxis: Place de la Musique turns into an African village for L'Afrique en couleurs , with artisan stalls and open-air concerts bringing the continent's sounds and flavors to Tour & Taxis.

Vaux-Hall: POMPOMPOM takes over one of the prettiest corners of Parc de Bruxelles, bringing together cider producers, live concerts and DJ sets. Come for the bottles, stay for the beats.

Parc Meudon: A bonus for the little ones: 11 puppet shows from Belgian and international companies on Saturday and Sunday — with the obligatory snacks and face-painting stands.

FOR FOOTBALL FANS: Union Saint-Gilloise takes on Anderlecht at the Marien Stadium in the Brussels derby on Sunday evening. Their last meeting there ended with a thumping 5-1 for les Unionistes. Anderlecht may have some unfinished business.

BRUSSELS CRIME WAVE: Michel Goovaerts, chief of the Brussels-Capital and Ixelles police force, has been named “Gold Commander” of Brussels’ six police zones, charged with fighting the escalating violence linked to drug trafficking — effective immediately, BRUZZ reports .

State of security: That follows a decision Wednesday evening to step up security measures after a series of shootings over the past week, including with increased police presence in the city’s most troubled areas at night. Brussels-Capital Region Minister President Boris Dilliès also called on mayors to consider implementing curfews or limiting to locals access to certain areas.

Picket line: That hasn’t done enough to reassure anti-crime activists, with Saint-Gilles residents organizing a rassemblement citoyen to protest gang violence in their neighborhood.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Manuela Schwesig may have found a solution to the crisis enveloping the SPD: The Mecklenburg-Vorpommern leader is uncoupling from the party brand .

Paris: Socialist Party leader Oliver Faure is set to join the left’s presidential primary , positioning himself as an alternative to Raphaël Glucksmann.

London: Andy Burnham wants to rein in the “cowboys” in the building sector, sparking concerns his plan will create more paperwork for builders.

Washington: Republicans have a problem with white and married women voters, according to recent polling .

Canberra: Anthony Albanese says nuclear energy doesn’t stack up — but investors may not see it that way .

AGENDA

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen participates in the Europe Forum.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in the Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City’s 49th Economic Policy Symposium in Jackson Hole.

— Fisheries and Oceans Commissioner Costas Kadis meets Cypriot Agriculture, Rural Development and Environment Minister Christos Senekis in Nicosia.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Andrzej Buła and Barry Cowen; former MEPs Ivan Vilibor Sinčić, Patricia Lalonde, Cécile Kyenge and Enrique Guerrero Salom; Commission Vice President Raffaele Fitto; Thomas Huddleston of the

University of Liège.

Celebrating Saturday: Former MEP Santiago Fisas Ayxelà; Principles for Peace's Evan O'Connell; Roger McShane of The Economist; Nestlé's Molly Phillips Fogarty; Tunku Varadarajan, American Enterprise Institute fellow; journalist Uliana Pavlova; Mirga Gražinytė-Tyla, Lithuanian conductor and POLITICO 28 alum.

Celebrating Sunday: MEP Philippe Olivier; Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadir; Heather Grabbe, senior fellow at Bruegel; former MEPs John Stuart Agnew, Guillaume Balas, Branislav Škripek and Amelia Andersdotter; Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance's Laura Shevlin; Berkshire Hathaway Chairman Warren Buffett; Belarusian leader Alexander Lukashenko; The Capitol Forum's Javier Espinoza; ORF's Johannes Perterer; and POLITICO's Tommaso Anselmi.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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